

Session 10: Paul's Prayer for an Apocalypse

Key Takeaways

- Jesus' identity as the beloved chosen one defines our identity as humans. His death becomes our death, his resurrection becomes our resurrection, and his rule over Heaven and Earth becomes our true calling as the images of God.
- Paul prays that God would give the people a spirit of revelation, so they might grow in their knowledge and understanding and be transformed by the apocalypse of Jesus.

A Prayer for Revelation and Resurrection Power: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 1:15-23

¹⁵ For this reason,
as I heard of y'all's faith in the Lord Jesus
and the love which is toward all of the holy ones,
¹⁶ I have not stopped giving thanks,
making remembrance on y'all's behalf in my prayers,
¹⁷ in order that the God of our Lord Jesus Messiah,
the Father of glory,
would give y'all a spirit of wisdom and revelation
in order to know him,
¹⁸ the eyes of y'all's heart having been illuminated
so that y'all would know
what is the hope of his calling,
what is the richness of the glory
of his inheritance among the holy ones,
¹⁹ and **what** is the surpassing greatness,
of his power toward y'all who trust,
in accordance with the working of the power of his might,
²⁰ which he worked in the Messiah
having raised him from the dead ones
and having seated him at his right hand
in the heavenly realm
²¹ above all rule and authority
and power and dominion
and every name that is named,
not only in this age
but also in the coming one,
²² and "he placed all things under his feet",
and gave him headship over all things in the church,
²³ which is his body,
the fullness of the One who fills all in all.

Ephesians 1:15-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Flow of Thought in 1:15-23

Ephesians 1:15: Paul hears that new communities of people are showing loyalty to Jesus, demonstrated by their love that extends across boundary lines.

Ephesians 1:16: Paul places himself in the prophetic role of intercessor, standing at the intersection of Heaven and Earth and holding these people before God.

Ephesians 1:17-19: Paul prays that the "Father of glory" (temple language) would give divine wisdom and an apocalypse (being able to see Heaven's reality on Earth) so that their innermost being ("eyes of the heart") would come to grasp three things.

1. The future to which God has called his people, the manifesting of divine glory by ruling creation in the love and power of God (1:17).
2. The future “inheritance” that is the glory of the new creation ruled by God’s holy people (1:18).
3. God’s life-creating power being available to those with believing loyalty (1:19).

Ephesians 1:20-23: An exposition on the divine power of resurrection life

- 1:20: The resurrection and exaltation of Jesus as cosmic ruler was the inauguration of God’s Kingdom, the new creation which now rules over our current age (Ps. 110; Dan. 7).
- 1:21-22a: Jesus was exalted as the true divine-human ruler of the cosmos, dethroning the “rulers, authorities, powers, and dominion.”
- The great temple of Artemis in Ephesus (see Acts 19) was the center of spiritual, cultural, and political power (Ps. 8). Paul is claiming that Jesus is the true authority to which all rulers are accountable.
- 1:22b-23: Jesus’ cosmic lordship is focused on one particular place in the present overlap of the ages, the *ekklesia* (“the called-out ones”), over which his authority is acknowledged and manifested in their worship and corporate life, which is “filled up” by the one who “fills all things.”

Key Themes in Ephesians 1:15-23

In Ephesians 1:17, Paul prays that believers would experience a “revelation” (Greek: ἀποκαλύψις / *apokalupsis*), an unveiling to see what can only be seen with eyes of faith, the exaltation of the crucified and risen Messiah.

Paul’s description of the enthronement of the crucified Lord in Ephesians 1:20-21 is modeled after multiple key texts in the Hebrew Scriptures.

Ephesians 1:20-21 Instructor's Translation

²⁰ ... in the Messiah, having raised him from the dead ones and having seated him at his right hand in the heavenly realm ²¹ above all rule ...

Psalms 110:1-2 NASB*

¹ Yahweh says to my Lord: “Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet.”

² Yahweh will stretch forth your strong scepter from Zion, saying, “Rule in the midst of your enemies.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ephesians 1:22 Instructor's Translation

And he placed all things under his feet ...

Psalms 8:4-6 NASB

⁴ What is man that you take thought of him, and the son of man that you care for him?

⁵ Yet you have made him a little lower than God, and you crown him with glory and majesty!

⁶ You make him to rule over the works of your hands;
you have put all things under his feet,

Daniel 7:13-14 NASB

¹³ “I kept looking in the night visions,
and behold, with the clouds of heaven
one like a Son of Man was coming,
and he came up to the Ancient of Days
and was presented before him.

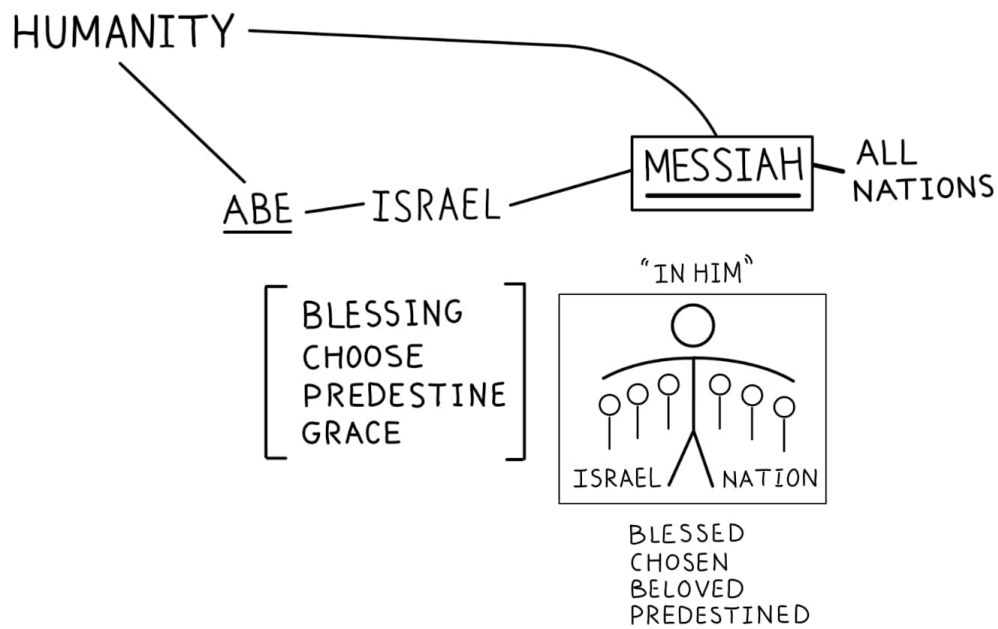
¹⁴ And to him was given dominion,
glory and a kingdom,
that all the peoples, nations and language
might serve him.

His dominion is an everlasting dominion ...

Jesus was the suffering and exalted Messiah of Israel who fulfilled God’s calling for Israel and all humanity. Now, the people of Jesus share in his death, resurrection, and exalted rule over the cosmos. Jesus’ followers can now know Israel’s true calling and purpose (Ps. 110 and Dan. 7), which was always meant to be the realization of humanity’s true calling and purpose (Ps. 8 and Gen. 1).

Here, Paul reflects the common “two age” cosmic thinking of the Hebrew prophets, who describe a coming Day of the Lord when God will act decisively to rescue his exiled and enslaved people, regather them in a new Jerusalem, and bring them under the reign of a messianic king in a new Jerusalem/Eden/creation.

Paul inherited the message that God’s Kingdom had truly arrived in Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection. Paul consistently views God’s Kingdom as decisively inaugurated in the present, with a future consummation to come. He makes this conviction clear by ascribing future realities to the present (Eph. 2:1-10).



Predestination of Israel. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Paul's Letter to the Ephesians (2019).

Reflection Question

How would you summarize the main point of Paul's prayer in Ephesians 1:15-23 in one sentence?